

MANUALLY OPERATED REPEATING RIFLES (1889–93)

By the final decade of the 19th century, the military authorities in all Western countries had adopted bolt-action repeating rifles for their infantry and other forces. These rifles were either of their own design or manufactured for them by major international arms companies. A reduction in caliber, and increase in range and velocity were features of this period. Rifles of this time, however, continued to use standard gunpowder, or “black powder,” as the primary propellant. This caused difficulties, such as obscuring of targets and fouling of barrels when a gun was fired. The French Lebel rifle leaped ahead in being the first small-caliber, high-velocity military rifle to use smokeless ammunition.



▲ CAVALRY CARBINE MODELLO 1891 TS

Date 1891
Origin Italy
Barrel 17¾in (45cm)
Caliber 6.5 × 52mm

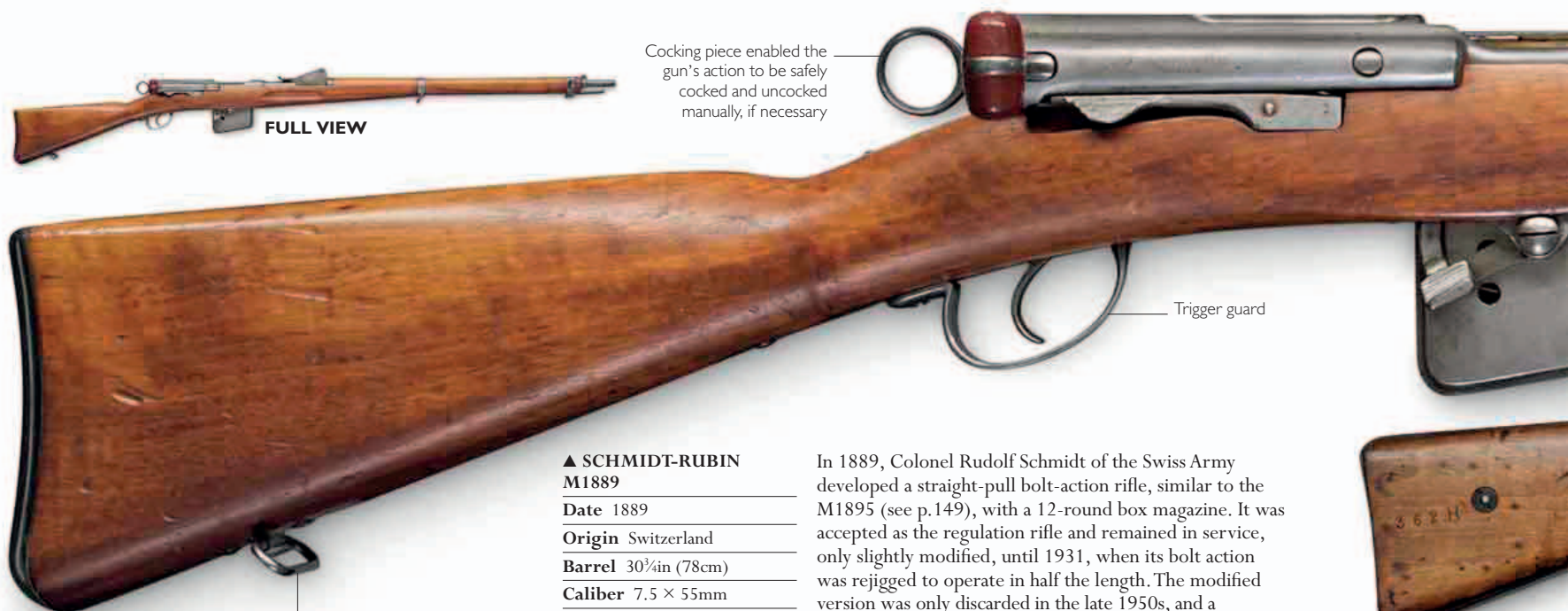
This gun was often known as the Mannlicher-Carcano. It continued, in modified form, in Italian service until after World War II, and many units were sold to dealers in the US; one found its way to Lee Harvey Oswald, who allegedly used it to kill President John F. Kennedy in 1963.

Wooden butt



FULL VIEW

Cocking piece enabled the gun's action to be safely cocked and uncocked manually, if necessary



▲ SCHMIDT-RUBIN M1889

Date 1889
Origin Switzerland
Barrel 30¾in (78cm)
Caliber 7.5 × 55mm

In 1889, Colonel Rudolf Schmidt of the Swiss Army developed a straight-pull bolt-action rifle, similar to the M1895 (see p.149), with a 12-round box magazine. It was accepted as the regulation rifle and remained in service, only slightly modified, until 1931, when its bolt action was rejigged to operate in half the length. The modified version was only discarded in the late 1950s, and a sniper's version was in use until 1987.

Rear sling attachment

Trigger guard



Wooden butt

Cocking piece

Bolt handle

Rear sight

Trigger

Trigger guard

Eight-round tubular magazine within the stock below the barrel